

Chapter 1. Fog

A thick fog hung over the street, making passage difficult even in broad daylight. The station seemed especially lonely in such weather. Few travelers passed by the closed shops.

The station master sat in his office, reading an old newspaper from 1891. The world seemed vast and frightening to him. There were exactly three houses standing near the edges of the square.

As evening fell, the city sank into deep silence. Candles in windows burned dimly and flickered in the wind. No one came or left through the station.

Chapter 2. The Letter

The letter arrived at the most unexpected moment, when the station master had long stopped hoping for any news.^[1] The envelope was wrinkled and dirty, as if it had traveled long roads. The address was written in a beautiful hand, though with some errors.

The station master opened the letter with trembling hands. "You were late," said Dr. Smith in a voice that seemed to come from the past. His heart began to race. There was still too much unclear.

He understood that everything must change now. The past returned unexpectedly. The future seemed uncertain and alarming, like a fog that would not lift.

¹ Author's note: this is a fictional story.